
Buddhism: Core Doctrines

Four Noble Truths, Pratityasamutpada, Kshanabhangavada, Anatmavada

Subject	Philosophy Optional Paper I
Topic	Buddhism - Indian Philosophy
Use	UPSC concept learning, revision, and answer-writing recall

UPSC anchor: Buddhism is part of Indian Philosophy in Philosophy Optional Paper I. This handout follows the learning session sequence: foundation first, then doctrinal connections.

Topic Roadmap

No.	Subtopic	Stage	Time
1	Four Noble Truths	Foundation	20 min
2	Pratityasamutpada / Dependent Origination	Core	25 min
3	Kshanabhangavada / Momentariness	Advanced	25 min
4	Anatmavada / No-Self	Advanced	25 min

Total estimated time: Concept learning 95 min + reflection/quiz 25 min + revision 20 min + MCQ practice 20 min = about 160 min.

1. Four Noble Truths

Core idea: Buddhism starts with suffering, identifies its cause, shows that it can cease, and gives a practical path for liberation.

Truth	Meaning	UPSC note
Dukkha	Suffering, dissatisfaction, anxiety, insecurity, and frustration in worldly life.	Wider than physical pain.
Samudaya	Cause of suffering: craving / trishna, attachment, and ignorance.	Explains why suffering arises.
Nirodha	Cessation of suffering; freedom from craving and ignorance.	Leads to nirvana.
Marga	The path to cessation, especially the Eightfold Path.	Practical and ethical discipline.

Diagnosis model:

Disease: Dukkha
Cause: Craving
Cure: Nirvana
Medicine: Eightfold Path

Exam point: Buddhism is not purely pessimistic. It is realistic and therapeutic because it diagnoses suffering and gives a path to overcome it.

2. Pratityasamutpada / Dependent Origination

Meaning: Everything arises due to causes and conditions. Nothing exists independently or permanently.

Basic formula:

Cause present -> effect arises
Cause removed -> effect ceases

For Buddhism, suffering does not arise randomly. It arises because of ignorance, craving, attachment, and karmic tendencies. If these conditions are removed, suffering can also cease.

Why it matters philosophically

- It rejects eternalism: things do not possess a permanent, unchanging essence.
- It rejects nihilism: things are not meaningless non-entities; they arise dependently.
- It supports the middle path: conditioned existence, not permanent existence and not total non-existence.

Link with Four Noble Truths

Samudaya becomes understandable because suffering has causes. Nirodha becomes possible because removing causes removes suffering.

3. Anitya and Kshanabhangavada / Momentariness

Anitya means impermanence: all conditioned things change. Kshanabhangavada is a stronger doctrine: all conditioned things are momentary.

Momentariness diagram:

Moment 1 -> Moment 2 -> Moment 3 -> Moment 4
A -> A' -> A'' -> A'''

What appears as the same object or person is actually a stream of changing moments. A movie appears continuous, but it is made of many frames shown rapidly. Similarly, life appears continuous, but Buddhism treats it as a sequence of momentary events.

Doctrinal connection:

Dependent origination explains how things arise.
Momentariness explains why they do not remain permanent.

Exam point: Do not say Buddhism believes nothing exists. Say: things exist momentarily and dependently, not permanently and independently.

4. Anatmavada / Doctrine of No Permanent Self

Core idea: Buddhism rejects a fixed, eternal, independent atman. The person exists conventionally as a changing stream of psycho-physical factors.

Skandha	Simple Meaning
Rupa	Body / material form
Vedana	Sensations / feelings
Samjna	Perception / recognition
Samskara	Mental formations / tendencies
Vijnana	Consciousness

Chariot analogy:

Parts together -> 'Chariot'
Skandhas together -> 'Person'

Just as there is no separate chariot beyond its parts, Buddhism says there is no separate permanent soul beyond the changing five skandhas.

Common confusion:

Wrong: Buddhism says the person does not exist at all.
Correct: Buddhism denies a permanent self, but accepts the empirical person as a dependent and changing stream.

Final Flow Diagram

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BUDDHISM
Indian Philosophy - Philosophy Optional Paper I
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v
FOUR NOBLE TRUTHS
|
|-- Dukkha: suffering, dissatisfaction, insecurity
|-- Samudaya: cause of suffering - craving / trishna
|-- Nirodha: suffering can cease
|-- Marga: path to cessation
|
v
Suffering is not permanent because it has causes
|
v
PRATITYASAMUTPADA
Dependent origination
|
|-- Everything arises due to causes and conditions
|-- Nothing exists independently
|-- If causes cease, effects cease
|
v
ANITYA
Impermanence of conditioned things
|
v
KSHANABHANGAVADA
Momentariness
|
|-- Apparent continuity is a stream of moments
|-- Movie frames analogy
|
v
ANATMAVADA
No permanent self
|
|-- No eternal independent atman
|-- Person = five changing skandhas
|
v
FINAL POSITION
Dependent arising -> Impermanence -> Momentariness -> No permanent self -> Liberation possible
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Compact UPSC Memory Chain

Dukkha -> Cause of dukkha: craving -> Pratityasamutpada -> Dependent and conditioned existence -> Anitya
-> Kshanabhangavada -> Momentariness -> Anatmavada -> No permanent self -> Nirvana becomes possible

Model One-Line Answer

Buddhism explains suffering through dependent origination, denies permanence through momentariness, and rejects a permanent soul through anatmavada.

Answer-Writing Reminder

- Use technical terms: dukkha, trishna, nirodha, marga, pratityasamutpada, kshanabhangavada, anatmavada.
- Show links between doctrines instead of writing them as isolated facts.
- Avoid the error: 'Buddhism says nothing exists.' Instead, write: things exist dependently and momentarily.

Source note: Based on the learning session and the UPSC syllabus framing for Philosophy Optional Paper I.